July 1897, carried a photograph of this ‘hole’, with a British officer in uniform and a local standing overlooking it. The photograph was titled ‘A Sutie Relic at an Indian Railway Station—Talgaria Station Platform—Bengal Nagpur Railway’, and the details went on to explain:

> In the foreground covered by the iron plates lies the relic of a Sutie. Sutie was a custom whereby Hindu wives allowed themselves to be burnt alive on the funeral pyre of their dead husbands. This spot is a sacred one. Pilgrims visit this relic, indifferent to the railway work that may be taking place. [10 4]

Another reference to it states that it led to labourers working there to frequently fall ill.

> On the Grand Chord line, there lies the station of Talgoria. As the track approaches the platform, it veers sharply to the right, loops around and becomes straight again; there is also an octagonal hole in the centre of the railway platform today. There is a tale behind both the curve of the track and that hole. The track was originally meant to be straight, and indeed was straight before it approached the station of Talgoria. However, when the track began to be laid in Talgoria in the 1930s, the coolies kept falling ill and refused to work. A holy man came and explained what was going on. That was a ‘suttee’ site, and it would be impossible to lay a track without bypassing that sacred spot, pronounced the holy man. As a result, the track makes a detour, and, as for the octagonal hole, it represents the sacred site. [105]

THE STORY OF TOILETS IN INDIA’S TRAINS

Early Indian trains did not have lavatories. They started being built into the coaches by the 1880s in the first and second classes. The common traveller in the third class did not have it then. By the 1870s, as the railway network spread far and wide in the country and train journeys became longer, there was growing noise in the local press and among activists demanding such facilities onboard trains. The usual practice then was for passengers to disembark at stations, but the problem was that third class passengers remained locked inside their compartments until the ticket collector came, sometimes for hours, complicating matters. Many rail companies experimented with water closets, but they didn’t work, and rail companies discontinued them, citing danger to health and excessive crowding. The Railways Act of 1890 made it mandatory to provide latrines on compartments reserved for ladies, though it still remained out of reach for third class passengers. It was finally in April 1902 that local governments were asked to ensure that the railways provided lavatories phase-wise in all